

BIG FIVE

One of the most famous personality tests is called the Big Five, which, as the name suggests, breaks down personality into five main areas. Psychologists use the Big Five to create questionnaires to find out how much of each quality an individual has. They agree that everyone should have at least a little of each.

CONSCIENTIOUSNESS

Reliable and hard-working people usually score high for conscientiousness. They strive to do well, though they can be fussy and sticklers for cleanliness. Those disorganized people who find homework and washing dishes dull and boring (isn't that everyone?) score very low here.

EXTROVERSION

Excitement and fun is what it's all about here. High scores indicate someone who is chatty and confident, with an appetite for danger. Low scores suggest an introvert, who adopts a more cautious approach to life.

NEUROTICISM

This is where the highly strung people are revealed. Those who get worried, excited, or upset very easily are likely to be emotionally sensitive and high scorers here. At the opposite extreme are calm and relaxed types of people, who rarely display their emotions.

AGREEABILITY

Whether you are friend or foe comes to light on this one. Good-natured and easygoing people do well here, while argumentative and bossy types fare worse. As a general rule, people become more agreeable with age.

OPENNESS

New experiences and challenges keep open people happy. They are spontaneous and prefer to try a number of things rather than committing to one. Those who score low here are probably simple types who prefer the familiar and stick to routines.

**"WE CONTINUE TO
SHAPE OUR PERSONALITY
ALL OUR LIFE."**

Albert Camus (1913–1960),
French author

CITRUS TEST

A scientific test can help decide whether you are more introverted (quiet, serious, and reserved) or extroverted (outgoing, adventurous, and talkative). Drop some lemon juice on your tongue and then collect your saliva in a glass. If you made a lot of saliva, you're likely to be more of an introvert, because introverts are more sensitive to stimulation. Take the test with a friend and compare the results.

AMBIVERTS

Everyone's a winner in the personality game. That's because most people are not complete extroverts or introverts. Instead, they're ambiverts, which means that they fall somewhere between the two. You might be quiet and shy with strangers but loud and confident with friends. Also, personality can change over time; for example, it is common for people to overcome shyness as they get older.